On

ON SEPTEMBER 20, FILMMAKER THEJA RIO PUT NAGALAND on the world map. His feature debut, *Angh*, about an indigenous village chief defiantly holding on to his faith as locals embrace Christianity and modern ways, was named the best film in the Platform section of the Toronto International Film Festival (TIFF). "I come from a small town in [the] Northeast of India where dreams don't often come true," said Rio, 31, in his speech. "I dedicate the award to the people back home.... This is just the beginning." That a film in Konyak, a language unfamiliar to most Indians, shot on 16mm film in the little-known village of Ghaspani, between Kohima and Dimapur, did this made it all the more impressive.

The award came with an additional distinction. *Angh* became the first film from Nagaland to be eligible to join the contenders for the Best International Feature Film category at the Oscars. Cameron Bailey, CEO of TIFF, was effusive about the 1960s drama, calling it a "magnificent...singular piece of work", the kind of which the festival has "never had the privilege to present before". The jury, which picked it over 11 other non-English language features, singled *Angh* out for its "deeply resonant portrait of a world" and Rio's "vision and audacity".

THE ROAD TO *ANGH*

Born and raised in Kohima, Rio began by writing rap before turning to short stories. It was while studying for a bachelor's in English literature at Delhi University that he'd tell film producer Nancy Nisa Beso, who had known him since age seven, about his aspiration to be a screenwriter. Beso was encouraging but honest about the ambition's harsh realities. "The industry is welcoming, but it's difficult to find your space and voice," says Beso, whose credits include independent films like *The Fable* and *Waiting*. "A career in filmmaking entails failures and unpredictability and requires belief." Luckily, Rio had plenty of it.

In 2015, he would be selected for a screenwriting programme in Sicily. Four years later, he made a short film iteration of *Angh*. Its warm reception at film festivals reinforced his idea of expanding it into a feature. It would land him a seat for a master's in direction at the National Film and Television School (NFTS) in the UK. He and Beso would collaborate for the first time on the short, *Ade (On a Sunday)*, about two friends who skip school one day and have a thorny run-in with the outside world, which would travel to renowned festivals like the Film Festival of Rotterdam. Says Beso, "He has a voice of his own, a spine, and he is methodical about how he wants to tell his story. His voice and conviction have grown stronger."

> **"I remained neutral so that my characters and conflicts could have depth and *Angh* wouldn't become a propaganda film"**
>
> **THEJA RIO**
> *Director,* Angh



THE BIG LEAGUE

For the first time, India will have not one but two films vying for the best International Feature at the Oscars. While Marathi drama *Gondhal* is India's official submission for the category, *Angh* has been named the best film in the Platform section at the Toronto International Film Festival, making it eligible for selection in this category according to a new rule. Whether *Angh* will join the 15 finalists will be known on December 15. The final five nominees will be announced on January 21. The last Indian film to be nominated in this category was *Lagaan* (2001).

BACK TO HIS ROOTS

Angh comes from Rio's own awakening. Much like the village chief's conflicted teenage son in the film, he recalls once feeling distant from his own culture and roots. "We didn't see ourselves represented in mainstream media. I never thought our stories were meant for the big screen," he says. Exposure to world cinema and his stint at the NFTS strengthened Rio's resolve. "The farther you drift from home, the more attached you feel to your roots," he says. "It was a journey before I started writing stories rooted in Naga culture." He turned to the Konyak people, a tribe largely inhabiting the forested hills of Mon district, bordering the India-Myanmar border; some of its warrior men were known for their tattooed faces. He is today "more conscious" about the stories he wants to tell. "I really enjoy making films about things I am conflicted about rather than things I am sure about," he adds.

That uncertainty, though, doesn't reflect in his filmmaking, for *Angh* has the stamp of an assured artist. Rio handles the gradual erasure of a village's sociocultural identity with restraint and nuance, refusing to vilify the Christian missionaries or judge any of its Konyak characters. Instead, he touches on betrayal, anxiety, complicity and human urges to be curious as well as cling to the past. He does so deftly by centring the narrative on the deteriorating relationship between a domineering father and his verbally challenged